

TOPIC 5: POLITICAL PARTIES

1. Meaning

A political party is an organised group of people who share similar political aims and seek to win elections in order to form or influence government. Parties present candidates, programmes and policies to the electorate.

2. Functions of Political Parties

- Recruit and present candidates for elections
- Educate and mobilise voters
- Formulate policies and alternative programmes
- Form government or act as opposition
- Provide a link between citizens and the state

3. Party System in Nigeria

Nigeria operates a multi-party system. Several parties are registered; in practice a few major parties dominate national contests. Parties must operate within the constitution and electoral laws. Healthy competition, internal democracy and issue-based politics strengthen democracy; ethnicity-based or violent politics weakens it.

4. Summary

Political parties organise competition for power. Their functions and the multi-party system are central to Nigerian democracy when they act responsibly.

End of Topic 5